the children and we played a match. Adolescents who had seen their parents attacked or killed joined the game with an eager gaiety and free-spiritedness that brought tears to my eyes. ‘I think this is the first time I have seen the children smile in weeks,’ one of the NGO activists told me.

Just a week later, Mulayam Singh, who had not even visited Muzaffarnagar once since the riots broke out, termed those in the relief camps as ‘agents of the Opposition parties’. Another SP leader said, ‘Those in the relief camps are like professional beggars found in every community.’

A month later, even as the riot victims were still battling compensation claims and slow-moving FIRs, the Yadav clan held their traditional Saifai Mahotsav in their village. Images of film stars dancing in front of the ruling Yadavs were contrasted with those who were spending their nights in camps in an unforgiving UP winter. The news outrage industry was having a field day. I remember questioning Shivpal Yadav on the 9 p.m. news on the need for a grand celebration in Saifai so soon after the riots. He shouted at me, and then walked out. It was another dramatic ‘TV moment’ that only mirrored the moral and political decline of the Akhilesh government.

Akhilesh had clearly betrayed the mandate of 2012. Everywhere I travelled in UP during the elections, one encountered an overwhelming sense of frustration. ‘*Akhilesh sarkar nahi chala sakte*’ (Akhilesh can’t run the government), was a familiar cry of anguish. It was a sullen anger waiting for an outlet to gush out. Modi provided the voter that escape route—he promised them deliverance from doom and gloom. The discredited Yadavs versus Modi’s promise of ‘hope’—it was a no-contest. I remember meeting a young Yadav student leader in Meerut who said he was voting for Modi. ‘Akhilesh has given us a laptop, but no bijli,’ he told me. ‘*Modi aayenge, bijli layenge!*’ (Modi will bring electricity.) UP’s youth were ready to cross the caste Rubicon. If even the Yadavs were looking to vote for Modi, then UP’s political earth was truly beginning to shake.

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